

ANGEL ACTION · NEUROLOGICAL

Stroke — The FAST Test

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The FAST test

- **F — Face.** Has their face drooped on one side? Can they smile evenly?
- **A — Arms.** Can they lift both arms and hold them there?
- **S — Speech.** Is their speech slurred? Can they understand you?
- **T — Time.** Time is brain — **call 000 immediately.**

Other signs include sudden numbness or weakness, sudden confusion, sudden vision loss, severe headache, dizziness or loss of balance.

What to do

1. **Call 000** — note the time symptoms started; this affects treatment.
2. Follow **DRSABCD**.
3. Lie the person down with their head and shoulders slightly raised.
4. Give **nothing to eat or drink** — swallowing may be affected.
5. Reassure them and stay with them.
6. If they become unconscious but are breathing, place them in the **recovery position**.
7. If they stop breathing normally, start **CPR**.

TIA (mini-stroke)

If symptoms resolve quickly, it may have been a transient ischaemic attack. Still call 000 — it is a warning sign of a major stroke.

Adapted from Australian First Aid 5th Edition. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.